



Benevolent House ACADEMY

Where Foundations Become Futures

PARENT HANDBOOK

508 N State Hwy 342, Red Oak, TX 75154
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Where Foundations Become Futures

*This handbook contains the policies and procedures of Benevolent House Academy.
Please read carefully and sign the acknowledgment page at the end.*

TABLE OF CONTENTS

SECTION 1: WELCOME AND MISSION	5
Our Core Values.....	5
Staff Identification.....	5
Contact Information	5
Handbook Review and Updates	5
SECTION 2: HOURS OF OPERATION AND HOLIDAY CLOSURES	5
Holiday Closures	6
SECTION 3: ENROLLMENT AND ADMISSION.....	6
SECTION 4: TUITION, FEES, AND PAYMENT POLICIES	6
Daytime Care Rates (Full-Time, 5-Day).....	7
School-Age Care	7
Night Care (6:00 PM to 6:00 AM).....	7
Drop-In Care.....	7
Fees	7
Supply Fee Proration Schedule	8
Discounts	8
Payment Policies	8
SECTION 5: WHAT TUITION INCLUDES.....	8
Specialty Items	9
SECTION 6: PROGRAMS AND SERVICES	9
SECTION 7: DAILY SCHEDULES AND ACTIVITIES.....	9
Master Daily Schedule (Daytime)	9
Night Care Schedule	10
SECTION 8: CURRICULUM AND EDUCATIONAL APPROACH.....	10
Screen Time.....	11
SECTION 9: DISCIPLINE AND GUIDANCE	11
Approved Guidance Techniques.....	11
Prohibited Methods.....	11
Behavior Classification and Response.....	11
Suspension and Expulsion	12
Biting Policy.....	13
Physical Aggression Policy (Hitting, Kicking, Pushing)	13
SECTION 10: RELEASE OF CHILDREN AND AUTHORIZED PICKUP	14
SECTION 11: SIGN-IN AND SIGN-OUT PROCEDURES	14
SECTION 12: LATE PICKUP POLICY	14

Late Pickup Fee	14
If We Cannot Reach You	15
Chronic Late Pickup	15
SECTION 13: PARENT COMMUNICATION (BRIGHTWHEEL)	15
SECTION 14: PARENT RIGHTS AND VISITATION	15
Breastfeeding	15
Access to Records and Reports	16
Access to Minimum Standards and Regulatory Information	16
Parent Rights Under Texas Law (TAC 746.521)	16
SECTION 15: PARENT INVOLVEMENT AND PARTICIPATION	16
SECTION 16: ILLNESS AND EXCLUSION CRITERIA	17
Illness During the Day	17
Communicable Disease Notification	17
SECTION 17: MEDICATION ADMINISTRATION	17
Medication Safety Plan	18
Unable to Reach Parent Regarding Medication	18
Epinephrine Auto-Injectors	18
SECTION 18: MEDICAL EMERGENCIES AND INJURIES	18
SECTION 19: HEALTH CHECKS	19
SECTION 20: ALLERGIES AND SPECIAL DIETARY NEEDS	19
SECTION 21: NUTRITION AND MEALS	19
Outside Food Policy	19
Infant Feeding	19
SECTION 22: PHYSICAL ACTIVITY AND OUTDOOR PLAY	20
Benefits of Physical Activity	20
Daily Physical Activity	20
Settings for Physical Activity	20
Outdoor Play	20
Physical Activity on Extreme Weather Days	20
Clothing for Physical Activity	21
SECTION 23: SAFE SLEEP POLICY (INFANTS)	21
SECTION 24: NAP AND REST TIME	21
SECTION 25: WHAT TO BRING AND LABELING REQUIREMENTS	21
SECTION 26: CLOTHING GUIDELINES FOR CHILDREN	22
SECTION 27: SUNSCREEN AND INSECT REPELLENT	22
SECTION 28: BIRTHDAYS AND CELEBRATIONS	22

SECTION 29: ANIMALS	23
SECTION 30: FIELD TRIPS.....	23
SECTION 31: WATER ACTIVITIES	23
SECTION 32: TRANSPORTATION	23
Transportation Emergencies.....	23
SECTION 33: NIGHT CARE	24
SECTION 34: EMERGENCY PREPAREDNESS	24
SECTION 35: CHILD ABUSE AND NEGLECT PREVENTION AND REPORTING	24
Prevention and Awareness.....	24
How to Report Suspected Abuse or Neglect.....	25
How to Contact Licensing.....	25
SECTION 36: IMMUNIZATION REQUIREMENTS.....	25
SECTION 37: HEARING AND VISION SCREENING.....	25
SECTION 38: LIABILITY INSURANCE NOTICE.....	26
SECTION 39: GANG-FREE ZONE NOTICE.....	26
SECTION 40: INCLUSIVE SERVICES FOR CHILDREN WITH SPECIAL CARE NEEDS	26
SECTION 41: VACCINE-PREVENTABLE DISEASES.....	26
SECTION 42: QUESTIONS, CONCERNS, AND GRIEVANCES.....	26
SECTION 43: TERMINATION OF SERVICES AND WITHDRAWAL	27
Withdrawal by the Parent.....	27
Disenrollment by the Center	27
Notice of Disenrollment	27
Refunds.....	28
SECTION 44: WEATHER CLOSURES AND CENTER CLOSURES.....	28
SECTION 45: PARENT ACKNOWLEDGMENT OF RECEIPT	28

SECTION 1: WELCOME AND MISSION

Welcome to Benevolent House Academy! We are a licensed, nonprofit childcare center located in Red Oak, Texas, serving children from 6 weeks through 13 years of age. Our licensed capacity is 52 children. We are licensed by the Texas Health and Human Services Commission (HHSC) Child Care Regulation division.

At Benevolent House Academy, we believe every child deserves a safe, nurturing, and joyful environment where they can learn, grow, and thrive. Our programs are designed to be developmentally appropriate for each age group, and our caregivers are trained to support the whole child, including their social, emotional, physical, and cognitive development.

Our staff is trained in best practices for early childhood education, including responsive caregiving, positive guidance, and social-emotional development. We understand that every child is unique, and we are committed to building strong, trusting relationships with both children and families.

Our Core Values

- **Safety.** The physical and emotional safety of every child is our highest priority.
- **Nurturing Care.** We provide warm, responsive care that helps children feel safe, seen, and valued.
- **Respect.** We treat every child, family, and team member with dignity and respect.
- **Partnership.** We are partners with parents in supporting their children's growth and development.
- **Excellence.** We hold ourselves to the highest standards of quality, compliance, and professionalism.

Staff Identification

All Benevolent House Academy employees wear BHA-branded shirts during operating hours so that parents, visitors, and children can easily identify authorized staff members at all times.

Contact Information

Benevolent House Academy, 508 N State Hwy 342, Red Oak, TX 75154. Phone: (469) 807-1221. Email: info@benevolenthouseacademy.org. Executive Director: Tanya Orr. Chief Operating Officer: Christopher Orr. Director: Tonya Dixon. Director: Haddie Mashburn.

Handbook Review and Updates

The Executive Director reviews this handbook at least once per year and updates it as needed to reflect changes in Texas licensing requirements, center operations, or best practices. Parents will be notified of any changes and will receive an updated copy. Questions about handbook content may be directed to the Director or Executive Director at any time.

SECTION 2: HOURS OF OPERATION AND HOLIDAY CLOSURES

Benevolent House Academy operates 24 hours a day, 7 days a week, year-round. Daytime care hours are 6:00 AM to 6:00 PM. Night care hours are 6:00 PM to 6:00 AM.

Holiday Closures

The center is closed on the following 11 holidays:

- New Year's Day
- Martin Luther King Jr. Day
- Memorial Day
- Juneteenth
- Independence Day (July 4th)
- Labor Day
- Thanksgiving Day
- Day After Thanksgiving
- Christmas Eve
- Christmas Day
- New Year's Eve

If a holiday falls on a Saturday, the center will be closed on the preceding Friday. If a holiday falls on a Sunday, the center will be closed on the following Monday. Tuition is due regardless of holiday closures.

SECTION 3: ENROLLMENT AND ADMISSION

Before a child is admitted to Benevolent House Academy, the parent or guardian must complete and sign the following:

- Enrollment application with complete admission information
- Child-care enrollment agreement (acknowledging receipt of these operational policies)
- Emergency contact and authorized pickup form
- Current immunization records (or approved exemption documentation)
- Statement of the child's health from a health-care professional
- Food allergy emergency plan (if applicable)
- Medication authorization form (if applicable)
- Liability insurance notice acknowledgment (Attachment A)
- Infant feeding plan and safe sleep acknowledgment (infant enrollment only)

All admission information must be signed by the parent before the child's first day. Admission information is reviewed and updated at least every 6 months. Infant feeding instructions are updated at least every 3 months. Parents are responsible for notifying the center immediately of any changes to contact information, authorized pickup persons, allergies, or medical conditions.

SECTION 4: TUITION, FEES, AND PAYMENT POLICIES

All tuition rates are weekly. Tuition is due each Friday in advance of the following week of care.

Daytime Care Rates (Full-Time, 5-Day)

Age Group	5-Day	3-Day (M/W/F)	2-Day (T/Th)
Infant (6 wks-11 mo)	\$265	\$200	\$145
Young Toddler (12-17 mo)	\$250	\$190	\$140
Toddler (18-35 mo)	\$225	\$170	\$125
Preschool 3 yr	\$195	\$145	\$110
Preschool 4 yr	\$185	\$140	\$100
Full-Time Scholar K-5th	\$185	\$140	\$100

School-Age Care

Service	Rate
Before/After School (4-day week)	\$115/week
Before/After School (5-day week)	\$135/week
Full Day (Summer/Breaks/Holidays)	\$175/week

Night Care (6:00 PM to 6:00 AM)

Service	Rate
Drop-in (per night)	\$75
2-3 nights/week (consistent schedule)	\$150/week
4-5 nights/week (consistent schedule)	\$225/week
24-Hour Combo (Day + Night)	\$325/week

Drop-In Care

Service	Rate
Daytime (2 yr and older)	\$65/day
Night	\$75/night

Fees

- **Registration:** \$75 per child (one-time, non-refundable).
- **Annual Supply/Activity Fee:** \$100 per child, due September 1st. Prorated for mid-year enrollment (see proration schedule below).
- **Transportation:** \$25/week.
- **Late Pickup:** \$1 per minute after your scheduled pickup time.
- **Late Payment:** \$25.
- **Returned Payment:** \$35.

Supply Fee Proration Schedule

Enrollment Month	Amount	Enrollment Month	Amount
September	\$100 (full)	March	\$50
October	\$90	April	\$40
November	\$85	May	\$35
December	\$75	June	\$25
January	\$65	July	\$15
February	\$60	August	Waived

After your first prorated payment, every family pays \$100 on September 1st going forward.

Discounts

One discount per family. Discounts cannot be combined. Verification is required at enrollment and annually by September 1st. Discounts are removed if verification lapses.

Discount	Amount	Verification
Sibling	10% off each additional child	Sibling currently enrolled, same household
Military	\$10/week per child	Valid military ID, DD-214, or dependent ID
First Responder	\$10/week per child	Valid department/agency ID (police, fire, EMS)
Teacher/Educator	\$10/week per child	Valid school district ID or current pay stub

Payment Policies

- Tuition is due each Friday in advance of the following week of care.
- Two weeks of written notice is required for withdrawal. Tuition is due during the notice period.
- Tuition is due regardless of holidays, weather closures, or absences.
- Part-time schedules are set days only (M/W/F or T/Th). Changes require two weeks of written notice.
- Drop-in care is available space permitting and for pre-registered children only.
- If the center is closed 5 or more consecutive business days due to weather or emergency, tuition credits will be evaluated on a case-by-case basis.
- Texas Workforce Commission (TWC) Child Care Services subsidies are accepted. Co-payment is due by the first day of each week.

SECTION 5: WHAT TUITION INCLUDES

Full-time enrollment includes the following at no additional charge:

- Breakfast, lunch, and afternoon snack daily (USDA CACFP program). Dinner is provided for children in night care.
- Standard brand diapers, wipes, and infant formula for children in the infant and toddler classrooms.
- All curriculum materials, classroom supplies, and learning activities.
- Field trips and special activities (no additional fees).
- Developmentally appropriate, high-quality programming.

Specialty Items

If your child requires a specific brand, hypoallergenic, sensitive skin, or specialty formula, diapers, or wipes due to allergies, medical needs, or personal preference, you must provide those items. There is no tuition reduction for parent-supplied items. All parent-provided items must be labeled with the child's first and last name.

SECTION 6: PROGRAMS AND SERVICES

Benevolent House Academy offers the following programs:

- **Daytime Care (6:00 AM to 6:00 PM):** Full-time (5-day), 3-day (M/W/F), and 2-day (T/Th) options for children 6 weeks through 13 years.
- **Night Care (6:00 PM to 6:00 AM):** Overnight care with awake caregivers on duty at all times. Drop-in and consistent weekly schedules available.
- **Before and After School Care:** Transportation to and from local schools, homework time, snack, and enrichment activities.
- **Full-Time Scholars (K-5th Grade):** A full-day program for school-age children whose families choose an alternative to traditional school enrollment. Includes academic support, enrichment, STEM activities, art, music, and physical activity. BHA does not serve as an accredited school and does not issue grades or transcripts.
- **Drop-In Care:** Available for children 2 years and older, space permitting, for pre-registered families.
- **Transportation:** To and from local schools for school-age children.

Children may not remain in continuous 24-hour care indefinitely. Per Texas licensing, a break in care is required each calendar day. The 24-Hour Combo rate is for families who use both daytime and nighttime care with the required daily break.

SECTION 7: DAILY SCHEDULES AND ACTIVITIES

Each classroom follows a daily schedule that is posted in the room and tailored to the developmental needs of the age group. The following is a general overview of the daytime schedule. Detailed age-specific schedules are available in each classroom and from the Director upon request.

Master Daily Schedule (Daytime)

Time	Activity
6:00 - 7:30 AM	Arrival, free play, breakfast preparation

7:30 - 8:30 AM	Breakfast (CACFP)
8:30 - 9:00 AM	Circle time, morning meeting
9:00 - 10:30 AM	Learning centers, structured activities, small group instruction
10:30 - 11:15 AM	Outdoor play (staggered by classroom)
11:15 AM - 12:00 PM	Lunch (CACFP)
12:00 - 2:30 PM	Nap/rest time
2:30 - 3:00 PM	Afternoon snack (CACFP)
3:00 - 4:00 PM	Afternoon learning activities, art, music
4:00 - 5:00 PM	Outdoor play (staggered by classroom)
5:00 - 6:00 PM	Free play, pickup, transition to evening care

Night Care Schedule

Time	Activity
6:00 - 7:00 PM	Dinner (CACFP)
7:00 - 8:00 PM	Quiet play, reading, wind-down activities
8:00 - 8:30 PM	Bedtime routine (wash, pajamas, teeth brushing)
8:30 PM - 6:00 AM	Sleep (awake caregivers on duty at all times)

SECTION 8: CURRICULUM AND EDUCATIONAL APPROACH

Benevolent House Academy provides a developmentally appropriate, play-based learning environment designed to support the whole child. Our infant through Pre-K 4 classrooms use the Experience Curriculum by Brightwheel, a research-based early learning curriculum system that integrates hands-on learning, creative exploration, and skill-building activities tailored to each age group. The Experience Curriculum is aligned with all 50 states' early learning standards, Head Start, and NAEYC guidelines, and is fully integrated with the Brightwheel platform for seamless lesson planning, developmental observations, and family engagement. Our school-age program (5 years and older) follows an enrichment-based approach that includes academic support, STEM projects, art, music, life skills, and physical activity.

Our approach balances structured learning with child-initiated exploration, and every classroom is designed to foster curiosity, confidence, and a love of learning.

Our programs incorporate three practices that make BHA unique:

- **Character Development:** Each month, the center focuses on a character trait such as kindness, courage, patience, or respect. Activities, stories, and recognition are tied to the monthly trait, helping children build strong character and positive habits.
- **Daily Social-Emotional Check-Ins:** Every classroom begins the day with a relationship-building routine that includes feelings boards, morning circles, and calm-down corners. Children learn to identify, name, and regulate their emotions in a supportive environment.
- **Family Connection:** We honor and celebrate the diversity of family structures. Our classroom activities, books, and discussions reflect that families come in many forms, and every family is valued.

Activity plans are posted in each classroom and updated regularly. Parents are welcome to ask questions about classroom activities at any time.

Screen Time

Benevolent House Academy limits screen time in accordance with Texas Administrative Code Section 746.2105. Screen time is not used for children under 2 years of age. For children 2 years and older, screen time is limited to educational content only, does not exceed the limits established by minimum standards, and is never used as a substitute for physical activity, outdoor play, or caregiver interaction. Screen time is always supervised by a caregiver.

SECTION 9: DISCIPLINE AND GUIDANCE

Benevolent House Academy uses positive, developmentally appropriate guidance techniques. We believe that children do their best when they feel safe, connected, and understood. Our caregivers are trained to respond to challenging behavior with empathy, consistency, and patience.

Approved Guidance Techniques

- Positive reinforcement and encouragement
- Helping children name and manage their emotions
- Redirection to appropriate activities
- Setting clear, consistent limits
- Offering age-appropriate choices
- Natural and logical consequences
- Modeling appropriate behavior
- Brief supervised separation from the group when necessary (not to exceed one minute per year of the child's age)

Prohibited Methods

The following discipline methods are strictly prohibited at Benevolent House Academy. Any employee who uses a prohibited method is subject to immediate termination.

- Corporal punishment of any kind (spanking, hitting, slapping, pinching, shaking, biting)
- Verbal abuse (threats, humiliation, profanity, shaming, derogatory remarks)
- Punishment associated with food, rest, or toileting
- Placing a child in a dark or locked room
- Requiring physical exercise as punishment
- Any form of discipline that is frightening or humiliating to a child

Behavior Classification and Response

To ensure consistency and transparency, Benevolent House Academy classifies behaviors into three levels. The center's response is proportional to the severity and frequency of the behavior.

Level 1 Behaviors (Low-Level Concerns): These are developmentally typical behaviors that are addressed through routine guidance techniques. Examples include not following classroom rules, difficulty sharing or taking turns, minor verbal conflicts with peers, crying or whining, and refusing to participate in activities. Response: Caregivers use redirection, emotion coaching, and positive reinforcement. Parents are informed through daily reports if the behavior is persistent.

Level 2 Behaviors (Moderate Concerns): These are behaviors that are disruptive, persistent, or that may cause minor harm to the child, other children, or staff. Examples include biting, hitting, kicking, or pushing other children; throwing objects at others; persistent defiance or refusal to follow safety rules; destructive behavior toward classroom materials or property; and spitting at others. Response: The behavior is documented in an incident report. The parent is notified on the day of occurrence. If the behavior is recurring, the behavior escalation process below is initiated.

Level 3 Behaviors (Serious Safety Concerns): These are behaviors that pose an immediate safety risk to the child, other children, or staff. Examples include severe physical aggression causing injury to another child or staff member, biting that breaks the skin, elopement (leaving the classroom or building without permission), self-injurious behavior, and threatening behavior toward staff or children. Response: The child is immediately separated from the group in a supervised area. The parent is contacted for immediate pickup. The behavior escalation process is initiated at the appropriate step based on severity, and may begin at Step 3 or Step 4 for the most serious incidents.

Suspension and Expulsion

Benevolent House Academy is committed to working with families before considering suspension or disenrollment. If a child's behavior is a concern, the following process will be followed:

1. **Step 1: Parent Conference.** The Director and caregiver will meet with the parent to discuss the behavior, identify possible causes, and develop a plan together. Strategies may include schedule adjustments, classroom changes, or referrals to outside resources.
2. **Step 2: Written Behavior Plan.** If the behavior continues, a written behavior plan will be developed in partnership with the family. The plan will outline specific goals, strategies, and a timeline for improvement.
3. **Step 3: Temporary Suspension.** If the behavior plan does not result in improvement and the child's behavior continues to pose a safety risk to themselves, other children, or staff, the child may be temporarily suspended (1 to 5 days) to allow time for the family and center to reassess the plan.
4. **Step 4: Disenrollment.** If all reasonable interventions have been exhausted and the behavior continues to pose a persistent safety risk, the center may disenroll the child. Parents will receive 5 business days of written notice with the reasons for the decision.

In cases where a child's behavior poses an immediate danger to themselves or others (such as severe physical aggression causing injury), the center may temporarily remove the child from the classroom and require immediate parent pickup. The behavior escalation process will begin at the appropriate step based on the severity of the incident.

Biting Policy

Benevolent House Academy recognizes that biting is a common, developmentally typical behavior in infants and toddlers. Young children may bite because they lack the language to express frustration, excitement, or sensory needs. Our response to biting is rooted in understanding the reason behind the behavior while keeping all children safe.

- **First incident:** The caregiver separates the children, comforts the child who was bitten, and provides first aid. The biting child is redirected using age-appropriate guidance. Both families are notified on the day of occurrence through an incident report. The caregiver documents the circumstances (time of day, activity, possible triggers) to identify patterns.
- **Second incident (or emerging pattern):** The Director reviews the documentation for patterns (time of day, specific triggers, transitions, specific children involved). The caregiver adjusts the classroom environment to reduce triggers (additional supervision during high-risk times, seating changes, sensory tools). The parent of the biting child is contacted for a conference (Step 1) to discuss what is being observed and to develop strategies together.
- **Third incident or continued pattern:** A written behavior plan (Step 2) is developed with the family. The plan may include shadow supervision (a caregiver positioned within arm's reach during high-risk times), introduction of sensory alternatives (teething toys, chew necklaces for age-appropriate children), schedule modifications, or referral to Early Childhood Intervention (ECI) or a behavioral specialist for evaluation. The Director monitors the plan daily.
- **Persistent biting after the plan is in place:** If biting continues despite consistent implementation of the behavior plan and the safety of other children remains at risk, temporary suspension (Step 3) may be used to allow the family and center to reassess whether additional support or a different environment may better meet the child's needs. Disenrollment (Step 4) is considered only after all reasonable interventions have been exhausted.

At every step, caregivers respond with empathy and without shaming. Biting is never treated as willful misbehavior in infants and toddlers. The goal is always to identify what the child is communicating and to teach alternative ways to express that need.

Physical Aggression Policy (Hitting, Kicking, Pushing)

Physical aggression such as hitting, kicking, pushing, or throwing objects at others is addressed with the same trauma-informed, progressive approach. The center's response considers the child's age, developmental stage, and the context of the behavior.

- **First incident:** The caregiver intervenes immediately to ensure safety, separates the children involved, and uses emotion coaching to help the child identify what they were feeling. The child who was hurt is comforted and given first aid if needed. Both families are notified through an incident report on the day of occurrence. The incident is documented with context (triggers, circumstances, time of day).

- **Second incident (or emerging pattern):** The Director reviews the documentation for patterns. The caregiver implements targeted strategies (proximity supervision, offering choices before frustration escalates, teaching replacement behaviors such as using words or walking away). A parent conference (Step 1) is scheduled to share observations and develop a collaborative plan.
- **Third incident or continued pattern:** A written behavior plan (Step 2) is developed with the family. The plan may include individualized support strategies, a modified schedule, a classroom change, visual cue cards for emotional regulation, or referral for outside evaluation or support services. The Director monitors the plan and communicates progress to the family regularly.
- **Persistent aggression after the plan is in place:** If the behavior continues to pose a safety risk to other children or staff despite consistent implementation of the plan, temporary suspension (Step 3) and, if necessary, disenrollment (Step 4) may follow. These steps are taken only when the center has exhausted its ability to maintain a safe environment for all children.

If a single incident of physical aggression results in serious injury to another child or a staff member, the center may require immediate parent pickup and begin the escalation process at Step 3 or Step 4 based on the severity of the incident. Parents of the injured child are notified immediately and provided with a written incident report.

SECTION 10: RELEASE OF CHILDREN AND AUTHORIZED PICKUP

Children will only be released to individuals listed on the child's authorized pickup form. If a caregiver does not recognize the person picking up the child, the caregiver will request a valid government-issued photo ID and verify the name against the authorized pickup list before releasing the child. If the person is not on the authorized list, the caregiver will contact the parent to obtain verbal or written authorization.

No child will be released to an unauthorized person under any circumstances. If a custody order restricts pickup by a specific individual, a copy of the order must be provided to the center and will be maintained in the child's file. All caregivers will be informed.

IMPORTANT: It is the parent's responsibility to keep the authorized pickup list current. Changes must be submitted in writing to the Director.

SECTION 11: SIGN-IN AND SIGN-OUT PROCEDURES

Parents are required to sign their child in and out of the center each day using the Brightwheel app. The sign-in/sign-out record serves as the daily tracking system required by Texas licensing and must be completed by the parent or authorized pickup person. Do not drop off or pick up your child without completing the sign-in or sign-out process.

If you are unable to use Brightwheel for any reason, a paper sign-in/sign-out sheet is available at the front desk.

SECTION 12: LATE PICKUP POLICY

Pickup must occur by your scheduled pickup time. If you are running late, you must call the center at (469) 807-1221 as soon as possible to notify us.

Late Pickup Fee

A fee of \$1 per minute begins immediately after your scheduled pickup time. The late fee is calculated from the scheduled time, not from the time you called to notify us. Late fees are added to your next tuition payment.

If We Cannot Reach You

If 30 minutes have passed after your scheduled pickup time and we have not been able to reach you by phone, we will begin calling the emergency contacts listed in your child's file. If we are unable to reach you or any emergency contact within one hour after your scheduled pickup time, we are required to contact local law enforcement and/or Child Protective Services, as we cannot provide care indefinitely without parental contact.

Chronic Late Pickup

We understand that occasional delays happen. However, chronic late pickup disrupts staffing, affects ratio compliance, and is not fair to our caregivers. The following applies:

- **1st, 2nd, and 3rd late pickups:** Late fee applied. Verbal reminder from the Director.
- **After 3 late pickups:** Written warning issued and placed in the child's file.
- **After 5 late pickups:** The Director and Executive Director will meet with the family to discuss the situation. Continued late pickup may result in disenrollment.

Late pickup incidents are tracked on a rolling 12-month basis.

SECTION 13: PARENT COMMUNICATION (BRIGHTWHEEL)

Brightwheel is the primary communication platform at Benevolent House Academy. Through Brightwheel, parents receive daily activity reports and photos, real-time notifications of illness or injury on the day of occurrence, messages about upcoming events and policy updates, and digital copies of incident reports.

Parents are expected to download the Brightwheel app, create an account, and enable push notifications upon enrollment. The Director will provide setup instructions and an invitation code during the enrollment process.

In addition to Brightwheel, the center communicates important information through posted notices at the front desk, parent conferences (available upon request), and direct phone calls for urgent matters. If you have questions or concerns at any time, you may contact the Director at (469) 807-1221 or by email at info@benevolenthouseacademy.org.

SECTION 14: PARENT RIGHTS AND VISITATION

IMPORTANT: Parents may visit the center at any time during hours of operation to observe their child, the program activities, the building, the premises, and the equipment without having to secure prior approval. This is your right under Texas law.

Breastfeeding

Parents have the right to breastfeed their child or provide breast milk for their child while in care. Benevolent House Academy provides a comfortable, private area with an adult-sized seat within

the center for mothers who wish to breastfeed. Breast milk must be labeled with the child's name and date and will be stored properly in the refrigerator.

Access to Records and Reports

Parents have the right to review their child's records, the center's most recent licensing inspection report, and the center's operational policies at any time during hours of operation. The most recent inspection report is also posted at the center.

Access to Minimum Standards and Regulatory Information

Parents may access the Texas Minimum Standards for Child-Care Centers (Chapter 746) online at www.hhs.texas.gov/childcare. You may also contact the Texas Abuse and Neglect Hotline at 1-800-252-5400 or visit the HHSC website at www.hhs.texas.gov for additional information about childcare regulation in Texas.

Parent Rights Under Texas Law (TAC 746.521)

Under Texas Administrative Code Section 746.521, a parent of a child enrolled at Benevolent House Academy has the right to:

- Enter and examine the center during hours of operation without advance notice.
- File a complaint against the center.
- Review the center's publicly accessible records.
- Review the center's written records concerning the parent's child.
- Receive HHSC inspection reports for the center and information on how to access the center's compliance history online.
- Have the center comply with a valid court order signed by a judge that prevents another parent from visiting or removing the child.
- Be provided with contact information for HHSC Child Care Regulation, including the department's name, address, and telephone number.
- View any video recordings of an alleged incident of abuse or neglect involving the parent's child, if such recordings are maintained by the center and are available. The parent may not retain any portion of a video depicting another family's child, and the center will notify in writing the parent of any other child captured in the recording before allowing the parent to view it.
- Obtain a copy of the center's policies and procedures.
- Be free from retaliation by the center for exercising any of the rights listed above.

Benevolent House Academy will never retaliate against any parent for exercising any of these rights. If you believe your rights have not been respected, you may contact HHSC Child Care Regulation at 1-800-582-6036.

SECTION 15: PARENT INVOLVEMENT AND PARTICIPATION

Benevolent House Academy welcomes and encourages parent involvement. There are many ways you can participate in your child's experience at the center:

- Volunteer to read in your child's classroom, assist with special events, or share a skill or cultural tradition.
- Attend parent events, open houses, and holiday celebrations hosted by the center.
- Communicate regularly with your child's caregiver and the Director about your child's progress, interests, and needs.
- Provide feedback on center policies and activities. Your input helps us improve.
- Join classroom field trips as a parent volunteer (subject to background check requirements).

If you are interested in volunteering, please speak with the Director. All regular volunteers must complete a background check.

SECTION 16: ILLNESS AND EXCLUSION CRITERIA

To protect the health of all children and staff, children who are ill must not be brought to the center. If your child shows any of the following symptoms, they must stay home:

- Fever of 100.4 degrees F or higher
- Vomiting or diarrhea
- Severe coughing or difficulty breathing
- Undiagnosed rash
- Pink eye (conjunctivitis) with discharge
- Head lice (until treated and nit-free)
- Any condition listed on the Texas DSHS Communicable Disease Chart for Schools and Child-Care Centers

Children may return when they have been symptom-free for at least 24 hours without medication, or when cleared by a physician.

Illness During the Day

If your child becomes ill during the day, we will separate them from the group in a supervised area and contact you immediately through Brightwheel and by phone. You or your authorized pickup person must pick up the child within one hour of notification.

Communicable Disease Notification

If a child or employee at the center contracts a communicable disease deemed notifiable by the Texas Department of State Health Services, all parents will be notified in writing within 48 hours. If there is an outbreak of lice or other infestation in your child's group, you will be notified within 48 hours.

SECTION 17: MEDICATION ADMINISTRATION

The center will administer medication to your child only with your written authorization. You must complete a medication authorization form that includes the child's name, medication name, dosage, time and method of administration, and any special instructions.

- All medication must be in the original, labeled container with the child's name.

- Prescription medication is administered only as directed on the label and in accordance with the physician's written instructions.
- Medications are stored in a dedicated medication storage area in the office, out of reach of children. Medications requiring refrigeration are stored in a small dedicated refrigerator in the office, separate from food items.
- A medication administration log is maintained and available for parent review.
- No over-the-counter medication will be given without written parental authorization and labeled instructions.
- Medications are returned to the parent when no longer needed. Expired medications are removed from storage immediately and returned to the parent. If the parent cannot be reached, expired medications are disposed of in accordance with safe disposal practices.
- The caregiver verifies the child's identity, medication name, dosage, time, and route before each administration.

Medication Safety Plan

If a child requires ongoing or emergency medication (such as an epinephrine auto-injector, inhaler, or seizure medication), the parent and the Director will develop a written medication safety plan that includes the condition, triggers, medication details, administration instructions, and emergency response steps. The plan is kept in the child's file and a copy is posted in the child's classroom (accessible to staff, not visible to other families).

Unable to Reach Parent Regarding Medication

If a question or concern arises regarding a child's medication and the center is unable to reach the parent after three (3) contact attempts (phone call to parent, then to each emergency contact on file), the center will contact Poison Control at 1-800-222-1222 for guidance. In a medical emergency, 911 will be called immediately regardless of whether the parent has been reached. Parent authorization is not required to administer medication in a medical emergency to prevent the death or serious bodily injury of a child, per TAC 746.3803(d).

Epinephrine Auto-Injectors

Benevolent House Academy does not maintain an unassigned epinephrine auto-injector at this time. If your child has a known risk of anaphylaxis, you must provide a current, unexpired, prescribed epinephrine auto-injector with a completed medication authorization form and a food allergy emergency plan. The auto-injector will be stored in the child's classroom in a location accessible to staff and out of reach of children.

SECTION 18: MEDICAL EMERGENCIES AND INJURIES

In the event of a medical emergency, staff will administer first aid and call 911 for life-threatening situations. Parents will be notified immediately. A written incident report is completed for every injury and illness, signed by the caregiver and the parent, and maintained in the child's file. Parents are notified on the day of occurrence regardless of the severity of the injury.

SECTION 19: HEALTH CHECKS

Caregivers conduct a visual health check of each child upon arrival each day. The health check includes observing the child for signs or symptoms of illness or injury, changes in behavior, and any visible marks or bruises. If a caregiver observes anything of concern, the parent will be asked for an explanation and the observation will be documented. If a child arrives showing signs of illness that meet the exclusion criteria, the parent will be asked to take the child home.

SECTION 20: ALLERGIES AND SPECIAL DIETARY NEEDS

Food allergies and dietary restrictions must be documented at enrollment. If your child has a food allergy, you must provide a completed food allergy emergency plan. Allergy information is posted in the kitchen (first name only) and communicated to all caregivers in your child's classroom. Caregivers verify each child's allergy information before serving meals. If your child has a life-threatening allergy, please discuss an individualized plan with the Director before enrollment.

SECTION 21: NUTRITION AND MEALS

Benevolent House Academy participates in the USDA Child and Adult Care Food Program (CACFP). Breakfast, lunch, afternoon snack, and dinner (for night care children) are served daily. All meals meet CACFP nutritional guidelines. Weekly menus are posted in the kitchen and near the parent sign-in area.

Outside Food Policy

As a general practice, outside food is not permitted at Benevolent House Academy. The center provides all meals and snacks, and our menu is designed to meet the nutritional needs of all children in care.

If your child has a documented sensory need, religious dietary requirement, or health-based or medical dietary need that cannot be accommodated by the center's menu, you may request to provide your child's meals and snacks from home. In accordance with TAC 746.3309(a), the following conditions apply:

- The parent must sign a written agreement (included in the enrollment agreement or as an addendum) stating that the parent is choosing to provide the child's meals and snacks from home.
- The parent must acknowledge in writing that the center is not responsible for the nutritional value of parent-provided food or for meeting the child's daily food needs.
- All parent-provided food must be labeled with the child's first and last name and date, and stored properly (refrigerated if needed).
- If a parent provides a meal but not a snack, the center will provide the snack.
- Parent-provided snacks may not be shared with other children unless the parent is providing baked goods for a classroom celebration and the items comply with the center's food safety and allergy policies.

Infant Feeding

Infants are fed according to their individualized feeding plan provided by the parent. Breast milk and/or formula are provided by the parent (unless using the center-provided standard formula). Iron-fortified infant cereal and age-appropriate foods are introduced based on the parent's written instructions and the child's developmental readiness. Infants are fed on demand and are never forced to eat.

SECTION 22: PHYSICAL ACTIVITY AND OUTDOOR PLAY

Benevolent House Academy promotes daily physical activity for all children as an essential part of healthy development. Physical activity builds strong bodies, supports brain development, improves coordination, and helps children regulate their energy and emotions.

Benefits of Physical Activity

Regular physical activity supports cardiovascular health, strengthens muscles and bones, improves coordination and balance, builds confidence, enhances social skills through cooperative play, and supports cognitive development and self-regulation. Benevolent House Academy is committed to ensuring that every child has daily opportunities for active movement.

Daily Physical Activity

Children participate in both structured (caregiver-led) and unstructured (child-initiated) physical activities each day. Outdoor play is scheduled at least twice daily for all age groups (staggered by classroom). Indoor physical activity (music and movement, dance, yoga, obstacle courses) is provided when outdoor play is not possible.

Settings for Physical Activity

Physical activity takes place in the following settings: the outdoor play area (primary setting for gross motor activities, riding toys, climbing, running, and group games), individual classrooms (music and movement, yoga, dance, and indoor gross motor activities), and the indoor common area (obstacle courses and large-group movement activities during inclement weather).

Outdoor Play

Children go outside daily unless weather conditions pose a significant health risk. The center uses the following criteria to determine when outdoor play is limited or moved indoors: temperatures at or above 100 degrees F (heat index), temperatures at or below 32 degrees F (wind chill), active thunderstorms or lightning, tornado warnings, heavy rain, ice, or other hazardous conditions as determined by the Director.

Physical Activity on Extreme Weather Days

On days when extreme weather limits outdoor play, indoor physical activity is provided to ensure children still have opportunities for active movement. Indoor alternatives include music

and movement sessions, dance, yoga, obstacle courses set up in the classroom or common area, and other structured gross motor activities led by caregivers.

Clothing for Physical Activity

Children should wear clothing and closed-toe shoes that allow them to run, climb, and move freely during outdoor and indoor physical activities. Please see Section 26 (Clothing Guidelines) for details.

SECTION 23: SAFE SLEEP POLICY (INFANTS)

IMPORTANT: This policy applies to all infants from 6 weeks through 12 months of age.

- Infants are always placed on their backs to sleep.
- Infants sleep in individual, safety-approved cribs that meet Consumer Product Safety Commission (CPSC) standards.
- Cribs contain a firm mattress and a fitted sheet only. No blankets, pillows, bumper pads, quilts, stuffed animals, toys, sleep positioners, loose sheets, attached pacifiers, pacifiers with clips, cords, or hooks, or any other soft objects or restrictive devices are allowed in the crib.
- Infants are never placed to sleep in swings, bouncers, car seats, or any device that is not a safety-approved crib.
- Infants who fall asleep in a location other than their crib are moved to their crib immediately.
- Swaddling is not permitted at the center.
- Caregivers visually check on sleeping infants frequently.

Parents are asked to review and sign the safe sleep acknowledgment at enrollment.

SECTION 24: NAP AND REST TIME

A daily rest period is provided from approximately 12:00 to 2:30 PM for all children. Infants follow their own individualized sleep schedule. Toddlers and preschool-age children rest on individual cots or rest mats with individual bedding (sheet and lightweight blanket). School-age children have cots or mats available if needed.

Children who do not fall asleep after 30 minutes are provided quiet activities such as books, puzzles, or coloring so as not to disturb sleeping children. We will not force your child to sleep, but all children are required to have a quiet rest period.

SECTION 25: WHAT TO BRING AND LABELING REQUIREMENTS

IMPORTANT: All personal items must be labeled with your child's first and last name. The center is not responsible for lost or unlabeled items.

- **All children:** A complete change of weather-appropriate clothing (including socks and underwear). A comfort item for nap time (small blanket or stuffed animal for children 12 months and older only).
- **Infants:** If your child requires specialty formula, diapers, or wipes not provided by the center, please bring a sufficient supply labeled with the child's name. Breast milk must be labeled with the child's name and date.

- **Night care:** Pajamas, toothbrush, and any comfort items for bedtime.
- **School-age:** Backpack with homework and school supplies. A water bottle (labeled).

Please do not send your child with toys from home unless the classroom has a designated show-and-tell day. The center is not responsible for lost, broken, or stolen personal items. Do not send items of significant value.

SECTION 26: CLOTHING GUIDELINES FOR CHILDREN

Please dress your child in comfortable, weather-appropriate clothing that they can play in freely. Children participate in outdoor play, art, and messy sensory activities daily, so clothing may get dirty.

- Closed-toe shoes are required for all children who are walking. No flip-flops, sandals, or open-toe shoes (they are unsafe for climbing equipment and outdoor play).
- Clothing should be easy for your child to manage independently during toileting (avoid overalls, belts, and complicated snaps for toddlers learning to use the restroom).
- During cold weather, please send a jacket, hat, and gloves. Children go outside daily unless weather conditions are dangerous.
- During warm weather, please apply sunscreen before drop-off. If you would like the center to reapply sunscreen during the day, you must provide the sunscreen (labeled) and complete an authorization form.

SECTION 27: SUNSCREEN AND INSECT REPELLENT

Benevolent House Academy does not provide sunscreen or insect repellent. If you would like the center to apply sunscreen or insect repellent to your child, you must:

- Provide the product, labeled with your child's first and last name.
- Complete a written authorization form specifying the product and when it should be applied.

We encourage parents to apply sunscreen before drop-off on days when outdoor play is expected. Staff will reapply during the day if authorization and a labeled product are on file. Only commercial, store-bought, EPA-registered products will be applied. The center will not apply homemade or unlabeled products. The authorization form specifies the type of product, the frequency of application, and any known sensitivities.

SECTION 28: BIRTHDAYS AND CELEBRATIONS

We love celebrating your child's birthday! If you would like to provide a treat for your child's classroom, please coordinate with the Director or your child's caregiver at least 3 days in advance.

- All treats must be store-bought with a visible ingredient label (no homemade food, per food safety guidelines).
- The Director will check the treat against the allergy list for your child's classroom before it is served.
- Please provide enough for every child in the classroom.
- Non-food celebrations (stickers, small books, pencils) are also welcome and encouraged.
- Please do not distribute individual party invitations at the center unless every child in the classroom is invited.

SECTION 29: ANIMALS

Benevolent House Academy does not keep animals or pets at the center. No animals are permitted on the premises during operating hours except for a special educational activity (such as a classroom visit from a local nature organization), in which case parents will be notified in advance. Children will only interact with animals under direct adult supervision, and any child with a known allergy to animals will be accommodated. All children wash their hands after any contact with animals.

SECTION 30: FIELD TRIPS

Benevolent House Academy offers occasional field trips for children. Written parental authorization is obtained for each field trip before departure. Child-to-caregiver ratios are maintained at all times. Each caregiver carries a roster with emergency contacts, a first aid kit is taken on all trips, and head counts are conducted before departure, at every transition, and upon return. Parents will be notified of upcoming field trips through Brightwheel with details about the destination, date, time, and any items needed.

SECTION 31: WATER ACTIVITIES

The center may use sprinklers for outdoor water play activities. When water activities are offered, children are directly supervised at all times, and children under age 5 are within arm's reach of a caregiver. Water play equipment is cleaned and sanitized after each use. No swimming pools or wading pools are located at the center, and children will not be taken off-site to a pool.

SECTION 32: TRANSPORTATION

Benevolent House Academy provides transportation for school-age children to and from local schools. Written parental authorization is required. Children are secured in age-appropriate safety restraints. A head count is conducted before departure and upon arrival. After all children exit the vehicle, the driver visually inspects the entire vehicle to ensure no child is left behind.

Transportation Emergencies

In the event of a transportation emergency (vehicle breakdown, accident, or medical emergency during transport), the following procedures apply:

- The driver or accompanying caregiver calls 911 immediately if there is an injury or imminent danger.
- All children remain secured in the vehicle unless the vehicle is unsafe (fire, smoke, or structural damage), in which case children are moved to a safe location away from traffic.
- The driver contacts the Director immediately to report the situation.
- The Director arranges for a replacement vehicle or alternate transportation and notifies parents of all children being transported.
- A head count is conducted immediately and continuously until all children are accounted for and safely returned to the center or released to their parents.
- An incident report is completed for every transportation emergency.

SECTION 33: NIGHT CARE

Night care is available from 6:00 PM to 6:00 AM. A minimum of 2 awake caregivers are on duty during all overnight hours. Children are provided age-appropriate sleeping arrangements: cribs for infants (bare cribs for children under 12 months), cots or mats for toddlers and older children with individual bedding. Parents provide pajamas, a toothbrush, and any comfort items.

The bedtime routine includes dinner, quiet activities, washing up, and preparation for sleep. Caregivers remain awake and maintain required ratios throughout the night.

Per Texas licensing, children may not remain in continuous 24-hour care indefinitely. A break in care is required each calendar day.

SECTION 34: EMERGENCY PREPAREDNESS

Benevolent House Academy maintains a written Emergency Preparedness Plan addressing fire, severe weather, lockdown, and other emergencies. Evacuation routes are posted in every room. Drills are conducted on the following schedule:

- **Fire drills:** Monthly.
- **Severe weather drills:** Quarterly.
- **Lockdown drills:** Quarterly.

In the event of an emergency requiring evacuation, children and staff will relocate to the nearest available designated relocation site. Benevolent House Academy maintains the following designated relocation sites:

- Oaks Church, 777 S I-35E, Red Oak, TX 75154 (primary daytime relocation site)
- Red Oak Fire Department, 111 Live Oak Street, Red Oak, TX 75154 (after-hours/alternate site)
- Benevolent House, 504 SH-342, Red Oak, TX 75154 (alternate site)
- Adventure Academy, 103 Houston School Rd, Red Oak, TX 75154 (alternate site)

The specific relocation site used will depend on the nature, location, and timing of the emergency. The Director or designee will determine the appropriate site based on the circumstances. Parents will be notified immediately through Brightwheel push notifications and phone calls with the specific relocation address. Emergency records for all children are transported with the group. A complete copy of the Emergency Preparedness Plan is available at the center for parent review upon request.

SECTION 35: CHILD ABUSE AND NEGLECT PREVENTION AND REPORTING

Every employee at Benevolent House Academy is a mandatory reporter under Texas law. Our staff is trained to recognize the signs of child abuse and neglect and to report suspected abuse immediately.

Prevention and Awareness

Benevolent House Academy is committed to preventing child abuse and neglect and to increasing awareness among employees and families. The center maintains the following practices:

- **Annual Employee Training.** All employees complete annual training on recognizing the signs and symptoms of child abuse and neglect, understanding risk factors, and fulfilling their legal obligation to report. This training is documented in each employee's personnel file.
- **Warning Signs and Risk Factors.** The center educates employees and parents on warning signs that a child may be a victim of abuse or neglect and factors that may place a child at increased risk. Information is shared during new employee orientation, annual staff training, and through parent resources available at the front desk.
- **Prevention Techniques.** Employees are trained in prevention techniques, including maintaining appropriate boundaries with children, proper supervision practices, and creating a safe environment. The center promotes open communication between families and staff to support early identification and intervention.
- **Community Coordination.** Benevolent House Academy coordinates with community organizations, including DFPS, local law enforcement, and family support agencies, to support child safety and connect families with resources when needed.

How to Report Suspected Abuse or Neglect

Parents are not required to report concerns to the center before contacting a regulatory agency. You may contact any of the following directly at any time:

- **Texas DFPS Abuse and Neglect Hotline:** 1-800-252-5400 (24 hours a day, 7 days a week)
- **Online:** www.txabusehotline.org

How to Contact Licensing

If you have concerns about this center or any childcare operation, you may contact:

- **HHSC Child Care Regulation (local office):** 1-800-582-6036 or (214) 583-4253
- **HHSC Website:** www.hhs.texas.gov/childcare

SECTION 36: IMMUNIZATION REQUIREMENTS

Each child enrolled at Benevolent House Academy must meet the immunization requirements specified by the Texas Department of State Health Services (DSHS) for their age. Current immunization records must be provided at enrollment and kept up to date throughout the child's enrollment.

Exemptions are available for medical reasons (signed by a physician) or for reasons of conscience, including religious beliefs (using the official DSHS affidavit form, which must be notarized). Children on provisional enrollment must complete required immunizations within the timelines established by DSHS rules.

SECTION 37: HEARING AND VISION SCREENING

Texas law requires hearing and vision screening for children ages 4 and older. Parents are responsible for ensuring their child receives the required screenings and providing documentation to the center. Screenings may be obtained through your child's pediatrician,

local school district, or a community screening event. If you need assistance locating a screening provider, the Director can provide referrals.

SECTION 38: LIABILITY INSURANCE NOTICE

As of the effective date of this handbook, Benevolent House Academy does not carry liability insurance due to financial reasons, as permitted under Texas Administrative Code Section 746.205. You were or will be provided with a separate written notice (Attachment A) about this before your child is admitted into care. You are required to sign that notice before your child's first day. A copy of the signed notice is maintained in your child's file.

When insurance is obtained, the center will carry a minimum of \$300,000 per occurrence as required by TAC 746.203.

SECTION 39: GANG-FREE ZONE NOTICE

Under the Texas Penal Code, any area within 1,000 feet of a child-care center is a gang-free zone. Criminal offenses related to organized criminal activity that occur in a gang-free zone are subject to harsher penalties under Texas law.

SECTION 40: INCLUSIVE SERVICES FOR CHILDREN WITH SPECIAL CARE NEEDS

Benevolent House Academy is committed to providing inclusive care for all children, including children with disabilities, developmental delays, or other special care needs, in compliance with the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA). We will make reasonable accommodations to support your child's participation in our program.

If your child receives Early Childhood Intervention (ECI) services or special education services, we welcome qualified service providers to deliver those services at our center with your written request and approval. We will work with you and your child's service providers to adapt activities, equipment, and routines as needed.

Caregivers integrate children with and without special care needs into all activities and adapt equipment and procedures as necessary to ensure that children with special needs are cared for in a natural environment.

If your child has special care needs, please discuss them with the Director during the enrollment process so we can develop an appropriate plan together.

SECTION 41: VACCINE-PREVENTABLE DISEASES

Benevolent House Academy maintains a policy on vaccine-preventable diseases as required by TAC 746.3611. The center encourages all employees to stay current on recommended immunizations to protect the health of children in care. Information about vaccine-preventable diseases and the center's employee immunization practices is available from the Director upon request.

SECTION 42: QUESTIONS, CONCERNS, AND GRIEVANCES

We value open communication with our families. If you have questions, concerns, or feedback about your child's care, classroom activities, or center policies, we encourage you to speak with the Director. Most concerns can be resolved through a direct conversation.

Parents are welcome to review and discuss any of the center's policies and procedures with the Director at any time. If you would like to schedule a meeting to discuss a specific policy, please contact the Director by phone at (469) 807-1221 or by email at info@benevolenthouseacademy.org.

If your concern is not resolved to your satisfaction, you may contact the Executive Director, Tanya Orr, by phone at (469) 807-1221 or by email at info@benevolenthouseacademy.org.

If you believe your concern involves a violation of licensing standards or child safety, you may also contact HHSC Child Care Regulation at 1-800-582-6036 or the DFPS Abuse and Neglect Hotline at 1-800-252-5400. You are never required to go through the center first before contacting a regulatory agency.

SECTION 43: TERMINATION OF SERVICES AND WITHDRAWAL

Withdrawal by the Parent

If you wish to withdraw your child from Benevolent House Academy, you must provide at least two weeks of written notice to the Director. Tuition is due in full during the two-week notice period regardless of whether your child attends. If you withdraw without providing two weeks of written notice, you will be responsible for tuition through the end of the two-week period.

If a child does not attend for 5 consecutive business days with no communication from the parent, the center will make reasonable attempts to contact the family. If no contact is made after 10 consecutive business days, the child may be disenrolled and the spot may be offered to the next family on the waitlist.

Disenrollment by the Center

Benevolent House Academy reserves the right to disenroll a child for any of the following reasons:

- Nonpayment of tuition. If tuition is more than 2 weeks past due and no payment arrangement has been made with the Director, the child may be disenrolled with 5 business days of written notice.
- Chronic late pickup (see Late Pickup Policy).
- Behavior that poses a persistent safety risk to the child, other children, or staff after the behavior escalation process has been followed (see Section 9).
- Falsification of enrollment records, immunization records, or any other documentation.
- Verbal or physical abuse, threats, or harassment directed at staff, other parents, or children by the parent or any authorized pickup person.
- Repeated violation of center policies after written warnings.
- Failure to provide required documentation (immunization records, health statement, allergy plan) within the timelines required by licensing.

Notice of Disenrollment

For non-safety reasons, the center will provide the family with 5 business days of written notice before disenrollment takes effect. The notice will include the reason for disenrollment and the effective date.

For safety reasons (including but not limited to threats of violence, a parent arriving under the influence of drugs or alcohol, or a child's behavior that poses an immediate danger after all interventions have been exhausted), disenrollment may be effective immediately. The center will provide written documentation of the reason as soon as practicable.

Refunds

If the center initiates disenrollment, any tuition paid in advance for days after the effective disenrollment date will be refunded. Registration fees are non-refundable. If the parent initiates withdrawal without proper notice, no refund is issued for the two-week notice period.

SECTION 44: WEATHER CLOSURES AND CENTER CLOSURES

In the event of severe weather, power outages, or other emergencies that make it unsafe to operate, the center may close temporarily. Parents will be notified as early as possible through Brightwheel push notifications, text message, and/or phone call.

Tuition is due regardless of weather-related closures. If the center is closed for 5 or more consecutive business days, tuition credits will be evaluated on a case-by-case basis by the Executive Director.

SECTION 45: PARENT ACKNOWLEDGMENT OF RECEIPT

I, the undersigned parent or legal guardian, acknowledge that I have received a copy of the Benevolent House Academy Parent Handbook (effective April 2026). I have read and understand the policies and procedures described in this handbook.

I understand that Benevolent House Academy reserves the right to modify, amend, or update the policies in this handbook at any time. I will be notified of any changes and will receive an updated copy.

I understand that my signed enrollment agreement and this acknowledgment serve as confirmation that I have been informed of the center's operational policies as required by Texas Administrative Code Chapter 746.

I understand that I may visit the center at any time during hours of operation to observe my child without prior approval.

A separate signature page is provided for parent acknowledgment and is maintained in the child's file at the center.